EM NO NAHI
by Tarun Bhartiya
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WHEN NO MEANS NO

RESISTANCE IS DEFENDING WHAT YOU LOVE, ASSERT TWO ICONIC DISSENTERS IN THIS PHOTOBOOK FROM THE AFTERLIFE



ON THE FRINGE Kong Spillity Lyngdoh Langrin's funeral, Domiasiat; a dam protest; (below) Photographer Tarun Bhartiya

KONG SPILLITY LYNGDOH LANGRIN led a decades-long protest against uranium mining in Meghalaya's West Khasi hills. The iron-willed matriarch of Domiasiat inspired poet and editor Tarun Bhartiya to memorialise her epic struggle in *Em No Nahi*. He used to joke that people talk of Northeast India only as "a sociological or anthropological category". But in the late 1980s, a scramble for rare earths attracted prospectors to the Khasi Hills, which has 13,000 tonnes of high-grade uranium deposits. A radioactive metal, uranium is mainly used to generate nuclear power. The ore, processed into powdery yellowcake using sulphuric acid, generates radioactive waste, which is stored in ponds and can leach into groundwater and cause serious health and environmental damage.

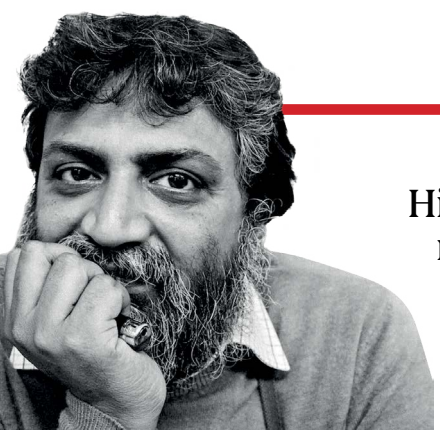
In Jharkhand's Jaduguda, Adivasi communities, workers and activists went to court, but the miners won after official assurances. The Khasis fought harder. Lyngdoh initially tolerated the prospectors but raised her voice after connecting acidifying water sources, dead cattle and still births in Domiasiat. In the early 2000s, when the Uranium Corporation of India tempted her with Rs 45 crore for a 30-year lease, she declared: "Money cannot buy me freedom."

Retaliation was brutal. Domiasiat's six households were denied roads and electricity, and its only school was shut down. Lyngdoh didn't blink. Backed by the Khasi Students' Union, she contributed to a 2016 state moratorium on mining. 'What else is resistance but defending what you love?' Tarun Bhartiya asks. His tour de force evokes Susan Sontag's observation that the camera's rendering of reality must hide more than it exposes. The monochrome photographs are raw and stark, framing landscapes, rituals, protests and daily life with a sensitivity that is part-photojournalism and part-film noir.

Bhartiya delighted in being the eternal outsider, a fact familiar to readers of his provocative webzine *Raiot* (a Khasi word for non-citizen). Yet, the book's sole colour photograph—storyteller and muse as comrades—is warm with camaraderie.

Lyngdoh died in 2020 at 95. Bhartiya followed in 2025, just 54, before this photobook appeared in print. In October 2025, the Union government exempted atomic mineral mining from mandatory public hearings. In Domiasiat, where uranium extraction has not commenced, the love story of resistance continues. ■

—Bijoy Venugopal



The story of the West Khasi Hill's protests against uranium mining is told through gritty but stylish photojournalism